coursera | MoMA

Seeing Through Photographs

Today's goal • 3/3 items

Module 1
Introduction to Seeing Through Photographs

Module 2
One Subject, Many Perspectives

Part I: Introduction
Introduction to Module 1 — Reading • 2 min
Artistic Equivalents — Reading • 2 min
Vik Muniz on Photographing the Familiar — Video • 3 min

Part II: Telescopes and Cameras
Introduction to Part II: Surface, Scale, and Technology — Video • 2 min
Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
Moons and Surfaces — Reading • 5 min
Hear More: Sarah Meister on Eugène Atget. Pendant l'éclipse. 1912 — Video • 3 min
Hear More: Liz Deschenes on Tilt/Swing (360° field of vision, version 1), 2009 — Video • 1 min
Surface, Scale, Technology — Dialogue • 15 min

Part III: Seeing the Unseen
Introduction to Part III: Man on the Moon — Video • 2 min
Photographs by NASA — Reading • 2 min
Hear More: Sarah Meister on U.S.G.S. and NASA, Surveyor III. Surface of the Moon, Day 319, W-F. 1967 — Video • 1 min
Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
Who Does the Moon Belong To? — Reading • 4 min

Part IV: It's Only a Paper Moon
Introduction to Part IV: Vernacular and Fine Art Photographs of the Moon — Video • 3 min
Moon Phases — Reading • 6 min
Hear More: Sarah Meister on Ansel Adams. Moonrise, Hernandez, New Mexico. 1941 — Video • 3 min
Man on the Moon and Paper Moons — Dialogue • 15 min

Part V: Review and Respond
Optional Readings and Resources — Reading • 10 min
Practice Memory Check — Practice Assignment • Grade: 100%
Optional Discussion Prompts and Creative Challenges — Reading • 10 min

Module 3
Documents and the Documentary

Part I: Introduction
Introduction to Module 3 — Reading • 2 min
Sarah Meister on Documents and the Documentary — Video • 3 min

Part II: Framing Reality
Facts and Fictions — Reading • 6 min
Fictions and Facts — Reading • 6 min
Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
Hear More: Mike Mandel on Evidence, 1977 — Video • 4 min
Hear More: Thomas Demand on Room (Zimmer), 1996 — Video • 1 min

Part III: Words and Pictures
Artist Spotlight: Dorothea Lange — Reading • 4 min
Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
Hear More: Sarah Meister on Dorothea Lange. Migrant Mother. 1936 — Video • 2 min
Hear More: Sarah Meister on Dorothea Lange. On the Road to Los Angeles, California. March 1937 — Video • 1 min
Artist Spotlight: Gordon Parks — Reading • 4 min

Part IV: Focus on New Documents, 1967
Introduction to Part IV: Sarah Meister on New Documents — Video • 3 min
New Documents: Arbus, Friedlander, and Winogrand — Reading • 4 min

Part V: Review and Respond
Practice Memory Check — Practice Assignment • 30 min
Optional Discussion Prompts and Creative Challenges — Reading • 10 min
Optional Readings and Resources — Reading • 10 min

Module 4
One and Another

Module 5
Constructing Narratives, Challenging Histories

Module 6
Pictures of People

Module 7
Ocean of Images

Facts and Fictions

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Anna Atkins



Anna Atkins. *Aspidium Lobatum*. 1853. Cyanotype (photogram), 12 3/4 × 8 5/8" (32.4 × 21.9 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift of Robert B. Menschel

In October 1843, the botanist and photographer Anna Atkins wrote a letter to a friend: "I have taken in hand a rather lengthy performance. It is the taking [of] photographical impressions of all, that I can procure, of the British algae and confervae, many of which are so minute that accurate drawings of them are very difficult to make." Motivated by the belief that the visual appearance of plants possessed both botanical importance and aesthetic interest, Atkins resolved to collect, classify, and picture these specimens in her published guide *Photographs of British Algae: Cyanotype Impressions*.

While previous scientists had supplemented their research with drawings or prints, Atkins sought "to obtain impressions of plants themselves." In pursuit of an accurate yet evocative mode of representation, she adopted a technology that had emerged just several years prior. Using the cyanotype process, Atkins placed algae specimens directly onto a chemically-coated paper and then exposed them to light. The resulting image was a blue-and-white print that she prized for their sharp contours and striking colors. Not only was Atkins the first person to publish a book illustrated with photographs, but she is also considered the first female photographer.

Carleton E. Watkins



Carleton E. Watkins. *Late George Cling Peaches*. 1889. Albumen silver print, 12 15/16 × 19 13/16" (32.8 × 50.3 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Acquired through the generosity of Jon L. Stryker

Often working on commission, Carleton Watkins photographed the landscape of the American West. As part of an assignment, Watkins was tasked with taking pictures of landholdings in Kern County, California, to attract prospective buyers to the region. He exposed hundreds of 8-by-10-inch glass plate negatives, including this closely framed photograph of a crate full of peaches. Among the qualities he was asked to emphasize were the fertility of the land and its ready access to water, both of which are evoked in this photograph of the plump pieces of fruit. To support this photograph's function as evidence, Watkins affixed to its mount a certificate vouching for the authenticity of its content.

Eugène Atget



Eugène Atget. *Boutique, 12 rue des Lyonnais*. 1914. Albumen silver print, 6 7/8 × 8 11/16" (17.5 × 22 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Abbott-Levy Collection. Partial gift of Shirley C. Burden

Eugène Atget made more than 10,000 pictures of Paris and its environs, including this print of a wine and liquor storefront. He focused on the fabric of the city: facades of individual buildings both celebrated and ordinary, meandering streetscapes, details of stone- and ironwork, churches, shops, and the occasional monument. At the time of his photographing, the city was undergoing massive renovations intended to modernize its medieval layout and infrastructure. Atget's photographs serve in part as records of the now mostly vanished "old Paris." These works also attest to his inventive methods of rendering the complexity of the three-dimensional world on the flat, rectangular plate of a photograph.

Unknown photographer



Unknown photographer. *Seventh Avenue, 42nd and 43rd Streets, New York City. View, Facing North, Along West Side of Seventh Avenue, Showing Sidewalk Conditions. Time 10:27am*. March 15, 1914. Gelatin silver print, 7 7/16 × 9 1/2" (18.9 × 24.1 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Acquired through the generosity of Barbara Foshay

Photographers often seek to capture a reliable view of the real world through a camera's lens. The photographer's purpose in taking this photograph, for example, was to record the specific street conditions of this stretch of Seventh Avenue. However, all photographs are necessarily shaped by how the photographer frames his or her subject, a process that introduces a personal point of view or perspective into even the most seemingly objective documentary photographs.

Zora J Murff



Zora J Murff. *Terri (talking about the freeway)* from the series At No Point in Between. 2018. Pigmented inkjet print, 40 × 32" (101.6 × 81.3 cm). Photo courtesy the artist and Webber Represents, London and New York. © 2020 Zora J Murff

Zora J Murff's At No Point in Between takes as its subject the historically Black neighborhood of North Omaha, Nebraska. The series weaves together intimate portraits, images appropriated from mass media and personal archives, and landscape photographs to tell the story of injustice and racist policies. *Terri (talking about the freeway)* documents a history of redlining (a discriminatory practice designed to segregate neighborhoods and deprive Black people of wealth) that has been deliberately suppressed and willfully forgotten by some.

About the series Murff states: "The work is a conversation about photography's objectivity; how we choose to believe in images (i.e., how belief systems are found, challenged, or reinforced through imagery); how images are contextualized and politicized."

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